A Multifaceted Recommendation for Techstars

TKS × techstars

A MULTIFACETED DEPLOYABLE RECOMMENDATION

Executive Summary

AN OUTLINE OF OUR RECOMMENDATION.

PROBLEM	SOLUTION	OUTCOME
The Mentor vetting process is laborious taking up to 100+ hrs. of valuable time over several months.	Among other things, our solution uses artificial intelligence, specifically natural language processing and deep learning.	Our solution can…
Mentors are lacking in diversity of vertical expertise and background.	Our solution has the potential to increase the efficiency and accuracy of the vetting process, optimize mentor to mentee pairing, and increase diversity.	Increase the efficiency of the vetting process up to 60%.
Mentors are being insufficiently engaged before or after the program.		Optimize mentor to mentee pairing.
		Increase diversity up to 20%.

Other

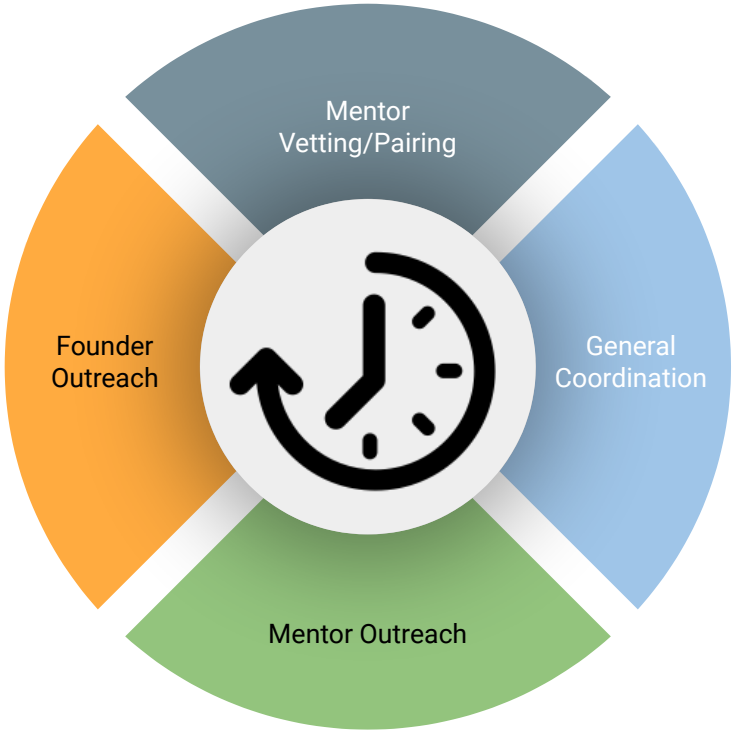
Main Tasks Ordered from 1-4 in Terms of Priority and Time Spent

1. **Founder Outreach to Satisfy Diversity Threshold**
   This is where most time has been spent in the past (100+ hours).

2. **Mentor Vetting/Pairing**
   Vetting through hundreds of mentor application also takes up a large portion of the time (100+ hours)

3. **Organizing Events/General Coordination**
   Organizing the main 3 month accelerator event along with other smaller events such as demo day.

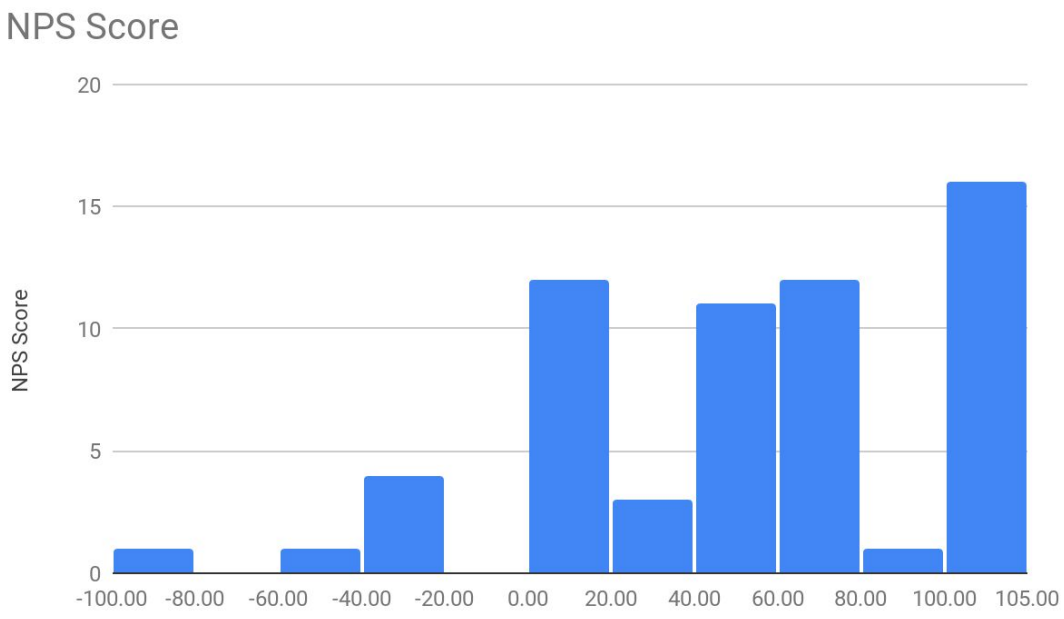
4. **Mentor Outreach and Communication**
   Techstars needs to work on investing at least 50 hours on reaching to more technically and ethnically diverse group of high-quality mentors.



Research of Problems

Mentor Feedback Analysis

BASED ON PAST TECHSTARS COHORTS



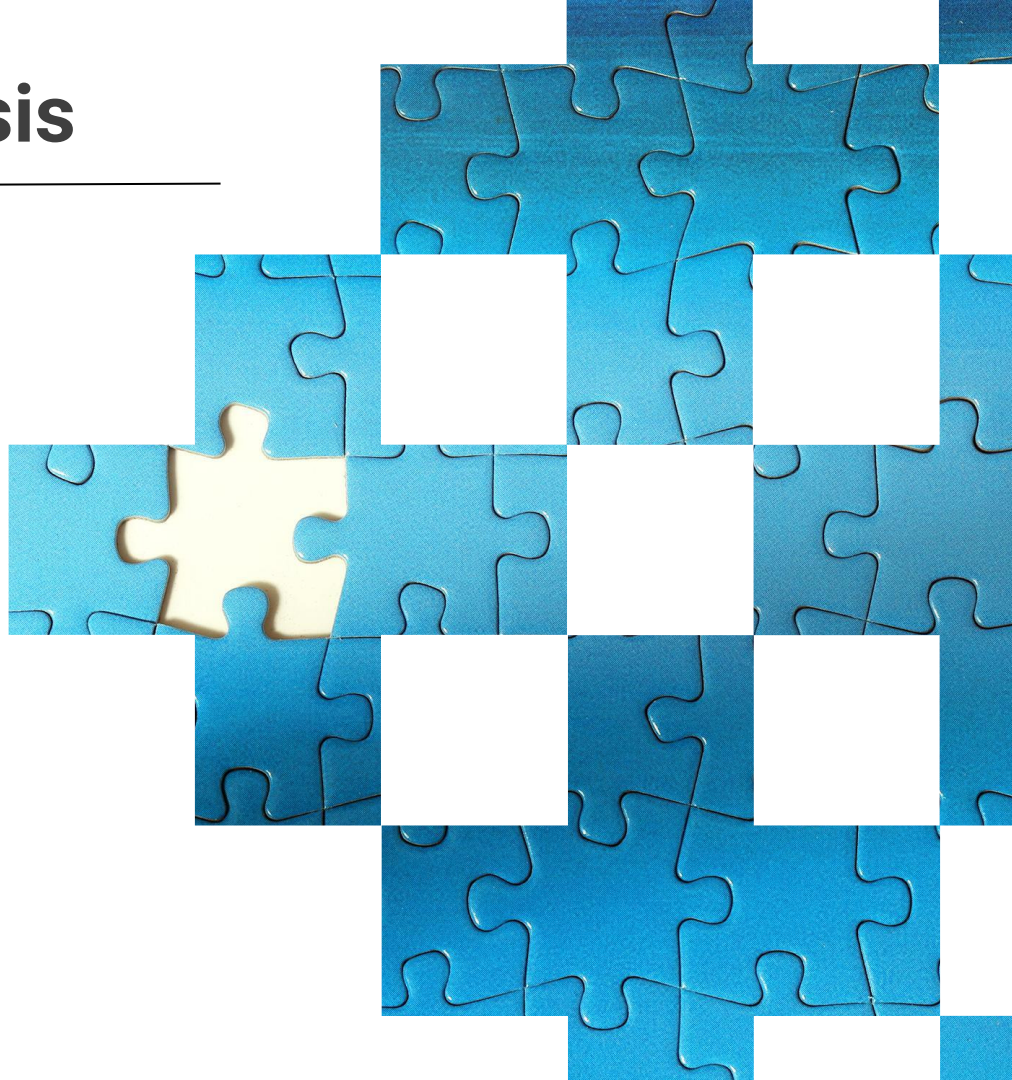
- **24% of Mentors received an NPS Score less than or equal to 20**

  18 out of 75 mentors received a score of less than 20.

  Additionally, 10-15 comments cite negative feedback about their overall experience working with a mentor

Mentor Feedback Analysis

- **Lack of alignment with goals**
  Most of the negative feedback comments related to a startup's mentor helping them, but not in the way they desired/expected
- **Lack of expertise**
  Many startups want advice and help specific to them, regardless of the industry of the mentor
- **Misalignment in character**
  Some startups found that their mentors were not a great fit in attitude, demeanor, or character
- **Lack of new resources**
  Some startups found that their mentor could not offer any new information or connections that they did not already have



Qualities of a Mentor

The mentors and founders we interviewed identified four key qualities of high quality mentors. Categories could be made to rank mentors based on the following 4 qualities.

Adaptability

Mentors must not be rigid in their approaches to solving a particular problem.

Technical/Business skill sets

Overlap in industry and mindset between mentors and mentees is essential, but it also helps to have mentors with connections and resources in other industries

Experience in Entrepreneurship

Mentors with unique experiences in entrepreneurship have had to overcome a number of challenges including product-market fit, marketing, and generating revenue.

Systems Based Teaching

Mentors should teach startups skills and mindsets that will help them succeed for not only three months, but three years!

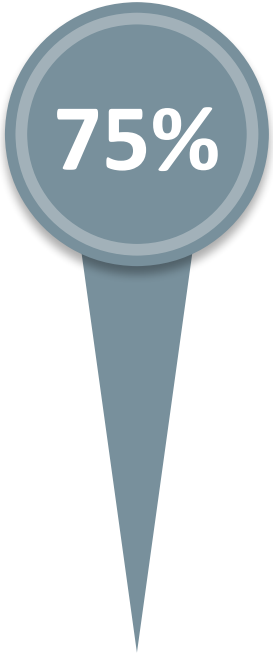
Statistics

Of the mentors and founders we interviewed...

Agree that mentor-founder compatibility is vital to the success of the startup

"A big part of running a startup is finding someone who can supplement what you can do. You really have to know what you're looking for so you can find the best person to help your company."

"[Startups] must figure out what their minimum success criteria is within a specific area or problem; this *must* align with the mentor's ability and goals for the relationship."



Believe that it is not necessary for a mentor to be in the same technical field as his/her paired mentee

"[Startups] need a diversity of experiences that different backgrounds can provide."

"The places where [startups] have problems are where they do not have experience. The startup role requires changing your world view time and time again, which requires people who have a different world view to point the way."

Statistics

Of the mentors and founders we interviewed...

65%

Believe that one of a mentor's most important qualities is their *character*

"Patience, empathy, integrity, and honesty are three of the most important qualities a mentor can have."

"Having a good understanding of personality and temperament is important in a mentoring experience because it can give insight into how an individual will interact with others, make decisions, and perceive a situation."

90%

Believe that routine communication is necessary for a strong mentor-founder relationship

"The ability to collaborate and communicate is key. Response time, and scheduling would key features on a mentor/ mentee platform."

"[Startups] *must* be open to an honest discussion about the plans for the business and are completely open to feedback; that's actually fairly rare. You can't give anyone advice if they aren't ready to take it."

Meet Yoshua Rozen

★ ★ ★ ★ ★

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supply chain,
ations who's
work based
improvement,
hile deliveries.
under 30 in El
ston

July 2016

Business Analyst - Global Market Department

June 2017

Founder and CEO of PartRunner Boston

Experience 55%

Confidence 10%

> **I would [mentor] to other startups; I feel I need more experience though."**

Email: yoshua.rozen@gmail.com

Kyle is genderqueer and has worked with StartOut, an LGBTQ+ startup accelerator for months. They are working on diversity & inclusion initiatives within different industries across the gender, sexuality, cultural, ethnic, and accessibility spectrums.

Meet Kyle Graden

September 2017

Cofounder and CMO of Seedum

May 2019

Member of StartOut, a diversity centered startup accelerator

June 2019

Founder and CEO of WitWay Planner + Business Development Manager

Experience

Confidence

I applied to TechStars, but did not hear feedback on why I was not accepted."

Email: contact@kylegraden.com

Meet Brandale Randolph

★★★★★

Brandale D. Randolph, is an author, guest lecturer and social entrepreneur, as well as the Co-Founder and former Executive Director of Project: Poverty, a nonprofit organization that aims to design, create and implement innovative strategies to reduce poverty.

November 2010

Co-founder and executive director of Project Poverty

June 2016

Founder of the 1854 Cycling Company

Experience 80%

Confidence 10%

"I am not yet an expert in my field and would not like to misguide others."

Email: brandalerandolph@1854Cycling.com

Refreshing Website Content

Mentor Survey Statistics

Forgoing Application Due to Doubt

20% of the People who responded to our google form believed that they didn't have experience. **Half of them come from minority groups (African americans, latinos, etc.)**

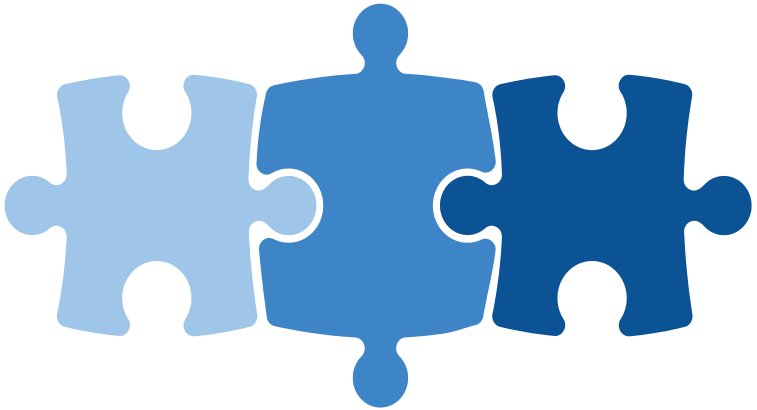
= 20%

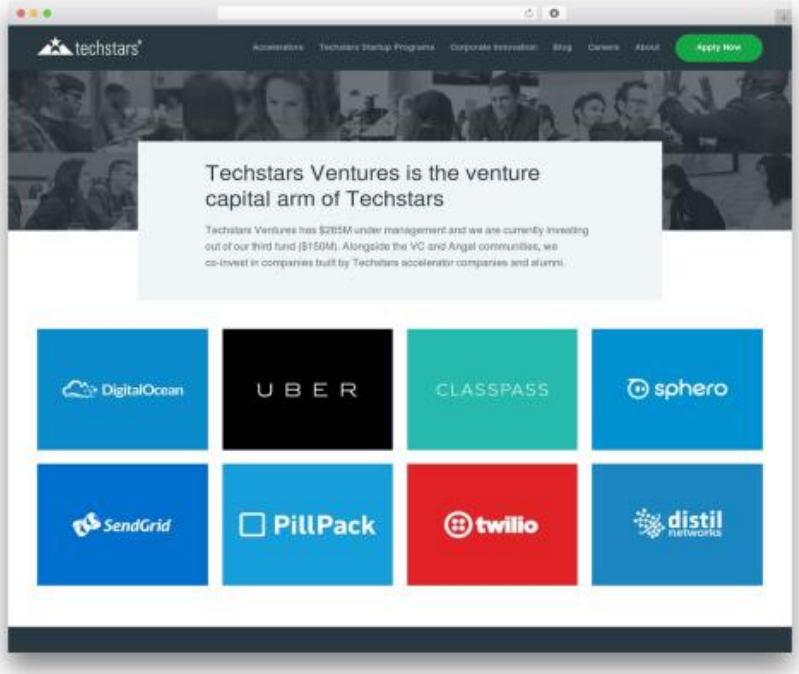
Level of Mentor Experience as a Priority

40% of the mentors who responded to our google form placed mentor experience as a first priority in terms of mentor qualities

= 42%

Refresh website content to focus on key BLANKS





Define Standard for Mentor Experience

1 in every 5 mentors we surveyed believed that they don't have sufficient experience.

Interactivity/Engagement

The google form is not interactive and doesn't provide mentors with all the info they need to know

Emphasize Focus on Diversity in Founder Population

Mentors may inherently make the assumption that Techstars resembles the majority of other accelerators, which put diversity to the side

Objective Requirements

Minimal Business/Educational Experience

Explicitly detail any degrees, or educational requirements. These objective requirements will persuade mentors with less confidence in their ability to apply.

Age/Years of Experience

Younger people with the experience required will be less intimidated.

Emphasize Priority on Diversity

Mentors from minority groups will be more likely to apply to techstars if they know that diversity is a priority.

Showcase the work being done by the Techstars Foundation via infographics and compare the techstars accelerator to other competitors.

*We understand that there shouldn't and can't be an exact formula that will help a mentor get into techstars. However, objective requirements may provide entrepreneurs from minority groups with the confidence to apply.

Mentoring at Techstars

We recommend but do not require that a mentor has the following business/educational requirements

- __ years of university
- __/__/__ degrees
- We require a minimum of __ years of experience in your profession.

Techstar's #1 priority is Diversity in our Founder Population.

A partner organization, the Techstars Foundation, conducts research allowing us to become Diversity Leaders in the accelerator ecosystem.

Gaps with this solution

Non-Advertisement Based

Our solution is focused on inbound opposed to outbound mentor engagement. that means that updating the website will focus on increasing mentors by simplifying the process and making applying much less intimidating

Website Editor Needed

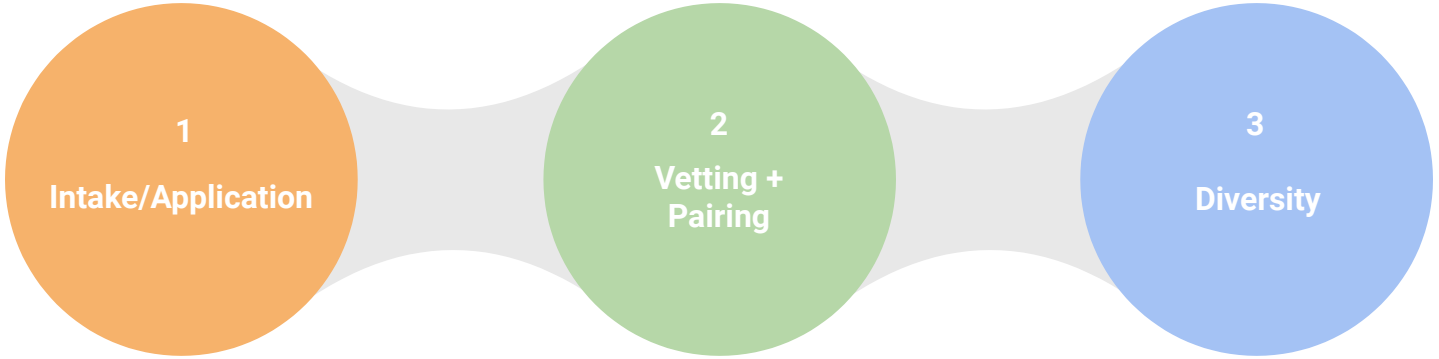
TechStars would need to enlist a website editor (if they do not already have one) to innovate their layout. They could also easily redesign the HTML and CSS for free using website editor like Brackets. It is a matter of time vs. budget/

Breaking Down Vetting

RESOLVING INEFFICIENCIES IN THE VETTING PROCESS.

Areas of Focus

WE FOCUSED ON THREE MAIN AREAS.



The application form of Techstars doesn't highlight all of their strengths, it is hard to find on the website, and the requirements for mentoring are not clearly outlined.

With discovery calls, 1-1s, and manually going through every single application for mentors AND startups, there are many ways this process could be made more efficient.

Current TechStars mentors lack diversity in the areas of ethnicity, gender, experience, and skills. By using AI to take unconscious bias out of the application process

Partially Automating Vetting

The current vetting process TechStars uses is extremely laborious, taking 100+ hours of work or more over months. This includes communication with mentors, creating a list of mentors with the right balance of skill sets, vetting, and setting up mentor office hours.

While interviewing potential mentors and building connections with them is important, vetting and creating a list of mentors with the right balance of skill sets could be made easier with the use of artificial intelligence, specifically natural language processing.

Natural language processing (NLP) is the ability of a computer program to understand human language as it is written or spoken. NLP and deep learning could help Techstars by autotagging resumes of mentors and sorting them by talent.

Manual Candidate Screening Is Not A Human Task

The volume of candidates to review is too large for humans.

Mentors must not be rigid in their approaches to solving a particular problem.

Humans are biased

Overlap in industry and mindset between mentors and mentees is essential, but it also helps to have mentors with connections and resources in other industries

AI

Teams should maximize their time connecting with candidates.

Mentors with unique experiences in product-market fit, marketing, and generating revenue.

Candidate screening machines work efficiently and accurately 24/7

Automating candidate screening ensures long-term consistency and quality. The AI will become highly specialized in candidate screening and surpass the quality of a single human trainer.

Manual Candidate Screening Is Not A Human Task

Time Commitment and Scalability

Recruiters currently skim resumes. If tagging is added to the process, they now need to read, interpret, and assign tags. This takes significant time and the only way to scale is to increase the number of people doing this manual review work.

Willingness and Completeness

Recruiters are unlikely to reinvent a process they have been doing a certain way for years. When some talent records inevitably fall through the cracks, the practice becomes far less valuable because some talent records remain 'dark data' that can't be surfaced easily.

AI

Accuracy and Consistency

As with any repetitious human task, accuracy will be an issue. People have different interpretations of words and ideas which will indefinitely lead to inconsistent metadata.

Measurement and Traceability

A human-driven process limits the capability to systematically trace the justification for hiring decisions. The process is centered around unstructured language such as employee reviews, descriptions of project work, or written communication.

Vettd.AI

NATURAL LANGUAGE PROCESSING.

Vettd.AI is an artificial intelligence event hub that uses natural language processing and deep learning to go through resumes of mentors and auto-tag them based on your own criteria, ranging from the sorting of skillset to gender.

1. With Vettd.AI, you can categorize talent profiles and resumes using your own customized taxonomy and neural-based classification engine. Explore these talent profiles to more easily look mentors for certain skills, job level, experience, and more.

2. Create and maintain a talent database that you can rely on for talent acquisition, strategic workforce planning, employee engagement, and more.

3. Backed by robust data, more informed talent decisions can be made quicker and with more confidence than ever. Vettd.AI holds the key to decreasing the amount of time needed to find mentors with certain attributes that are needed for specific startups, having the potential to increase diversity and optimize mentor to mentee pairing.

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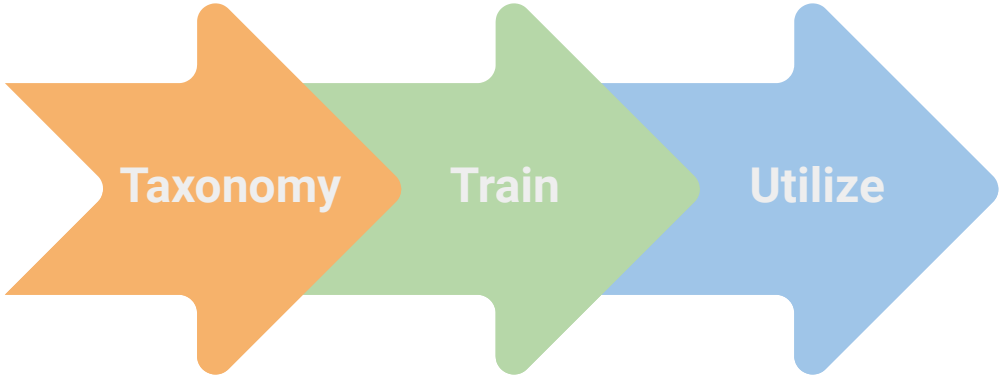
Vettd.AI

DEPLOYMENT.



Create your taxonomy

Make your own attributes to sort potential mentors by. If sorting mentors by skill set, possible tags could include marketing, sales, product development, tech, etc.

Train your custom AI model

Data (past Techstars mentor applications) are needed to train the neural network. Vettd.AI will help you turn it into an AI model capable of automating a mission-critical task.

Use and Integrate into your own HR software

Coordinate with Vettd.AI to deploy your classification AI model into your workflows.

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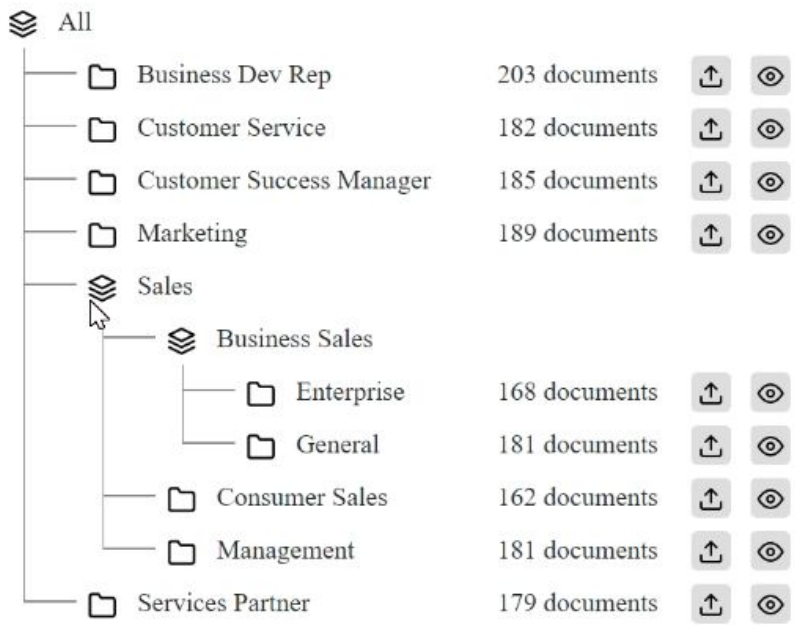
Vettd.AI will help make this a reality in as little as “a few days.”

An Inside Look at Vettd.AI

HOW IT WORKS.



This an example of a customized neural network architecture used to classify mentors' applications based on skill sets. You can customize your own taxonomy to sort mentors into customized categories. In this example, skills include customer service, marketing, management, etc.

The cost of Vettd.AI is dependent on the number of attributes, or in this case skills, your taxonomy has. This architecture costs $150.00 monthly, about 15 dollars for each attribute. (Subcategories, or attributes with stacked squares next to them, are free of cost.) Vettd.AI is flexible with cost.

This neural network will first need to be trained. The CEO of Vettd.AI, Andrew Buhrmann, recommends that the network be trained with past Techstars mentor applications.

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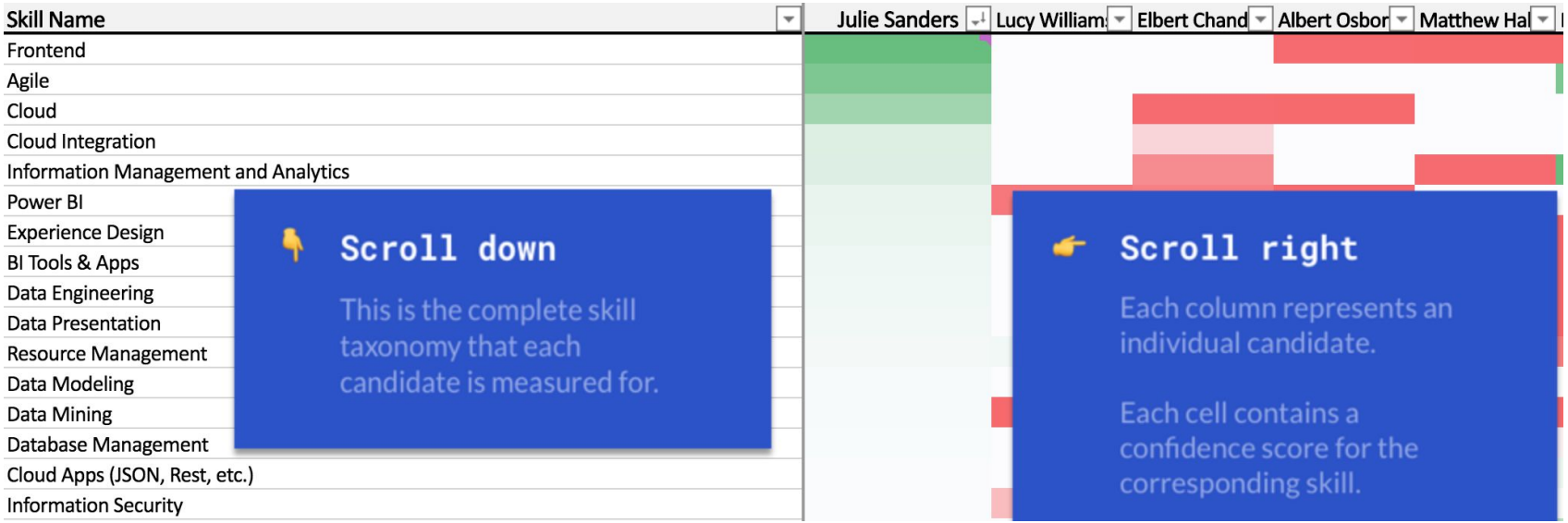
An Inside Look at Vettd.AI

THE RESULTS.



This is an example candidate classification for one of Vettd.AI's clients. Each column represents a potential mentor, and each cell within a column represents the confidence score that the potential mentor has the skill listed in the row. This took 5 seconds. This system gets deployed into the recruiter workflow to be used in real-time. After interviewing a startup and finding out what specific skills or backgrounds it lacks, you would reference this list and select interviews with the potential mentors who have the missing skill or background. Potential mentors could also be categorized by race, gender, or other attributes to ensure diversity in background among mentors. This solution has the potential to be integrated in all cities as well.

Who to Contact

Or shoot an email to mike.s.taylor101@gmail.com for a warm intro.

Andrew Buhrmann, CEO and President of Vettd

After speaking with Andrew, it's clear that he would love to help implement Vettd.AI into Techstars, both locally in Boston and globally. He believes it would help Techstars make the right decisions when pairing mentors to mentees and decrease the time spent on the vetting process.

The best part about Vettd.AI is that no in-house expertise is required. Vettd.AI will greatly help you create your own neural network and taxonomy, as well as implement it into your very own workflow.

LinkedIn: https://www.linkedin.com/in/andrewbuhrmann/
Email: andrew@vettd.ai

Pymetrics: Another Possible AI-Based Solution

ONLINE AI RECRUITMENT PLATFORM

Pymetrics pioneers ethical AI, leveraging cutting-edge data science and I/O psychology to help companies increase their recruiting efficiency and candidate diversity, improve employee retention, and future-proof their workforce.

1. Behavioral Insights: Better + Unbiased Data: pymetrics' gamified assessments and video interview collect objective, behavioral data that is free of bias, unlike resume data or self-report data.

2. Custom AI trained on the company's top performers: Maximize prediction + increase efficiency through customized but automated machine learning algorithms

3. Ethical AI: De-Biased Algorithms: Not all algorithms are created equal. Not only have the pymetrics games proven to be free of gender and ethnic bias, but prior to deployment, pymetrics checks each algorithm and removes any source through our open-sourced algorithm auditing tool, Audit-AI

4. Common Application: Rejected candidates can automatically match to other opportunities across other clients (for TechStars, other mentors or startups) using pymetrics, improving the overall candidate experience

5. Diversity: companies using Pymetrics like Unilever and Vodafone have found that blind evaluation procedures helped them recruit from more diverse backgrounds.

Statistics from Pymetrics

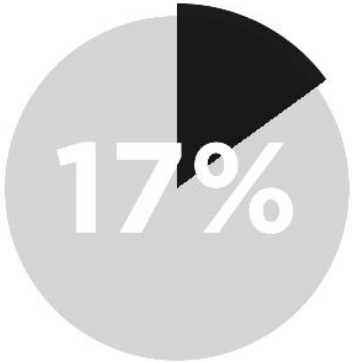
Ineffective

The average job receives 250 applications, yet the candidate chosen by the company **fails 30-50% of the time**

Biased

Resume review leads to women and minorities being at a **50-67% disadvantage**

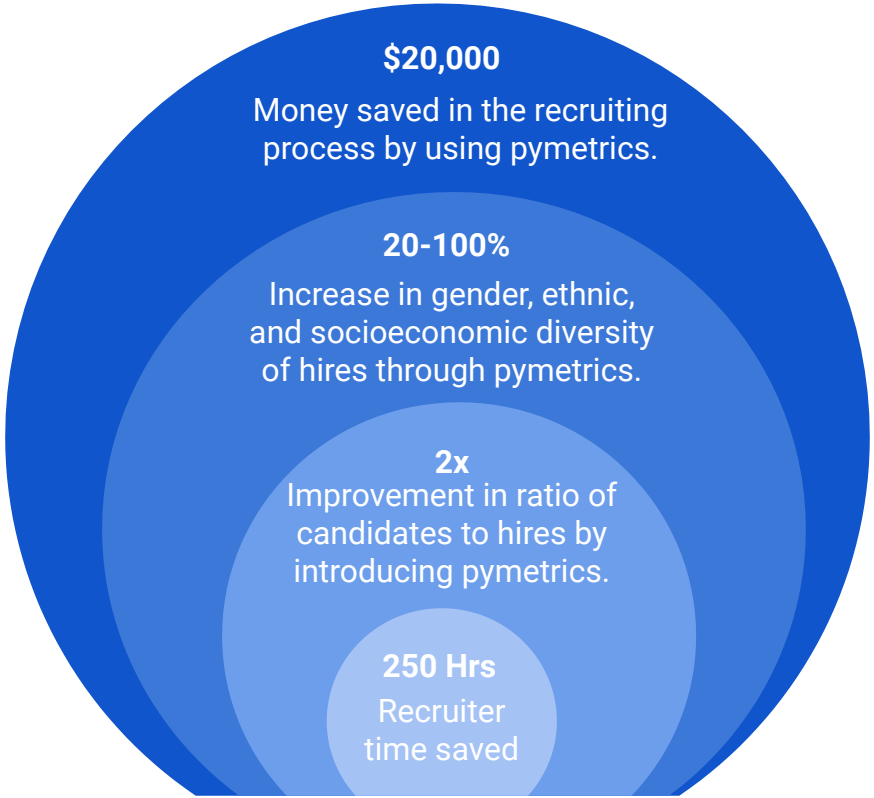
Poor experience



83% of candidates rate their experience as poor, and **45% of applicants never even hear back** from the company

With Pymetrics...

For a company with 5,000 potential candidates to sort through...



TechStars is likely to see...

- 75% reduction in time to hire
- 98% improvement in candidate experience
- 2x increase in candidate yield
- 50% increase in candidate retention

Pymetrics Process

1 **Existing employees play pymetrics neuroscience games**

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2 **Pymetrics analyzes trait data and trends are identified**

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3 **Pymetrics builds custom algorithms representing success and audits for bias**

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4 **Candidates play games and match to opportunities**

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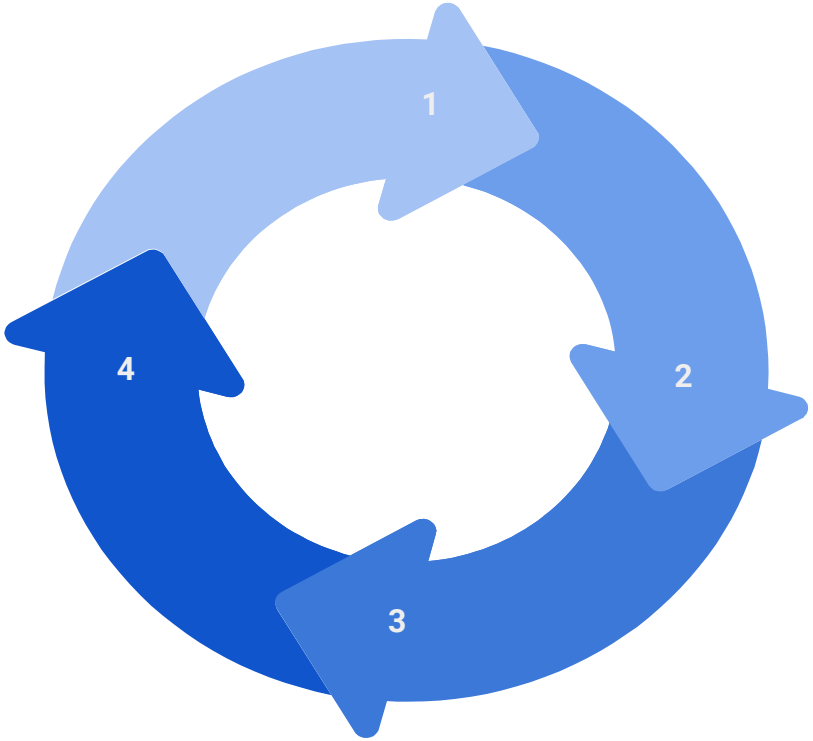


Companies like LinkedIn, Mastercard, McDonalds, Hyatt, and Global Asset Management have transitioned to Pymetrics as the new way to hire employees

Who to Reach out to at Pymetrics

Julian Dandridge

Client Success Manager

julian.dandridge@pymetrics.com

Bianca Ghiselli

Head of Global Client Success,

Global Strategy, and Operations

bianci.ghiselli@pymetrics.com

Elizabeth Burkly

Client Operations Manager

elizabeth.burkly@pymetrics.com

Applied: Another Possible AI-Based Solution

ONLINE AI RECRUITMENT PLATFORM

Applied is a recruitment platform designed to allow teams to measure candidates on what actually matters for your specific industry

1. Quality of Hire: Applied has found ways to improve recruitment and reduce bad hire occurrences as a result of years of research. The platform uses the most predictive forms of assessment to ensure you have all the tools to get the best person for the job, every time.

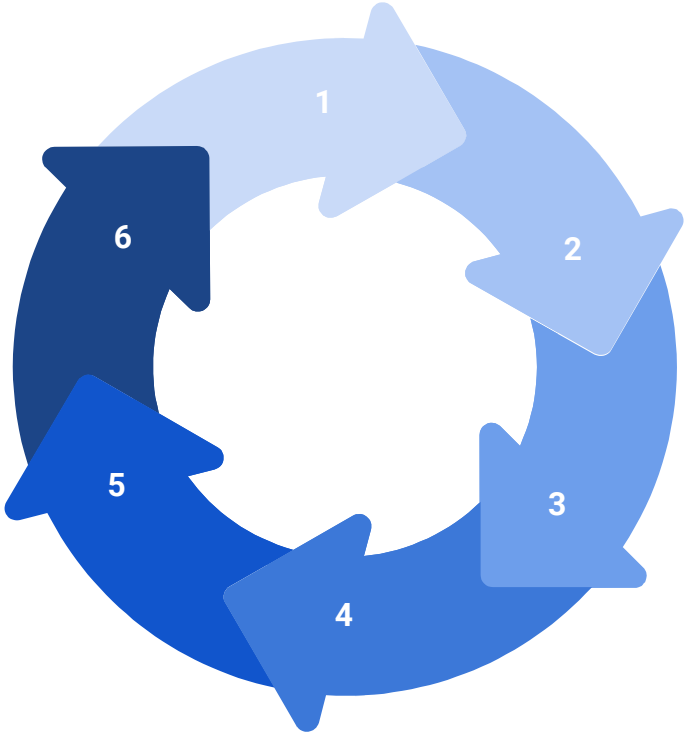
2. Streamlined Process: The traditional recruitment process is full of time-heavy activities that don't necessarily add value to applicants or hiring teams. With a streamlined and fair approach to candidate assessment, you'll be able to focus your time on the things that matter, ensuring you curate the best talent shortlist.

3. Diversity and Inclusion: There are several mechanisms built into the Applied platform that ensure companies hire the best person for the role, regardless of their background; these including blind reviewing, job board analysis, gender decoding and diversity reporting.

4. Candidate Experience: Every candidate that is run through the platform receives automatic, useful feedback throughout the application process.

Applied Process

1. **Build compelling job descriptions; construct role around ideal skills**
2. **Attract: choose job boards using job board analysis to tailor advertising.**
3. **Review: platform anonymises every candidate, randomising their answers, and each reviewer scores a set of answers**
4. **Shortlist: candidate scores are visualised and ranked to choose which ones to interview; all unsuccessful candidates receive automatic feedback on how their application performed.**
5. **Interview: invites send directly from the role dashboard; interviews remain objective by being held from within the platform**
6. **Hire: use all data to easily choose the best candidate for the role**



Companies like ASOS, Penguin Random House, and HM Government have transitioned to Applied as the new way to hire their employees

Who to Reach out to at Applied

Vesa Popova
Customer Success Manager

Bradley Franks
Growth and Partnerships Manager

Jade Allan
Head of Client Growth Management

Connect with them on LinkedIn to learn more about how their AI could revolutionize your current systems.

AI Comparison Pricing

Approximations based annually

Applied (Basic Platform)	Vettd.AI	Pymetrics
$4032	**$1800**	**$3600***
Role-level job board sourcing reports	Email Marketing	Email Marketing
Automatic candidate feedback	Content Creation	Content Creation
Unlimited roles, users and candidates	Integration with Sales Cloud	Integration with Sales Cloud
Assessment diagnostics	100K Automations	0 Automations
Data Extension (15GB)	Data Extension (45GB)	Data Extension (1GB)

*It is hard to accurately predict pricing without exact quotes from each company

Advantages of AI

FOUR OF THE ADVANTAGES OF AUTOMATING THE VETTING AND PAIRING PROCESS

Time Over Time

The AI processes may take a couple of days/weeks to deploy depending on the features needed, but they will save countless hours in the long run

Diversity

AI reduces all bias from the application process and makes it easy to narrow down matches; a focus on diversity-based recruiting also encourages more diverse applicants

Mentor Quality

AI will allow TechStars to hone in on the exact traits they want from their mentors and discover skills and qualities that aren't clearly present on regular applications

Focus on Outbound

With so much time and energy saved in innovating the vetting/pairing process, TechStars can now spend more time looking for new places to discover talent and resources

Gaps with these solutions

Deployment and Budget

Without a TechStars representative to ask for a specific quote on what they need, it is difficult to give exact estimates on time and budget for each possible AI solution to the vetting/pairing process

Like-Like Comfort

Many experts we talked to said that people of the same gender and ethnicity usually rather be paired with someone like them; by concealing these factors in the

Human Connection

TechStars is worried about losing the human connection part of their vetting/pairing process, but this human connection is a fundamental part of the accelerator itself and stays a large part of the mentor discovery process

Salesforce

Evaluating Multiple Marketing Platforms to Optimize for Maximum Communication and Outreach

By increasing efficiency of the work that involves fewer interpersonal interactions (Vetting, Data acquisition, Storage), Techstars can dramatically increase efforts on promoting diversity and mentor outreach.

Feature Analysis

Feature	Marketo	Salesforce	Hubspot	Airtable	Startup Tree
Data Storage		✓	✓	✓	
Simplicity	✓			✓	
Customer Journey		✓			✓
Segmentation	✓	✓	✓		✓

The Problem

Data

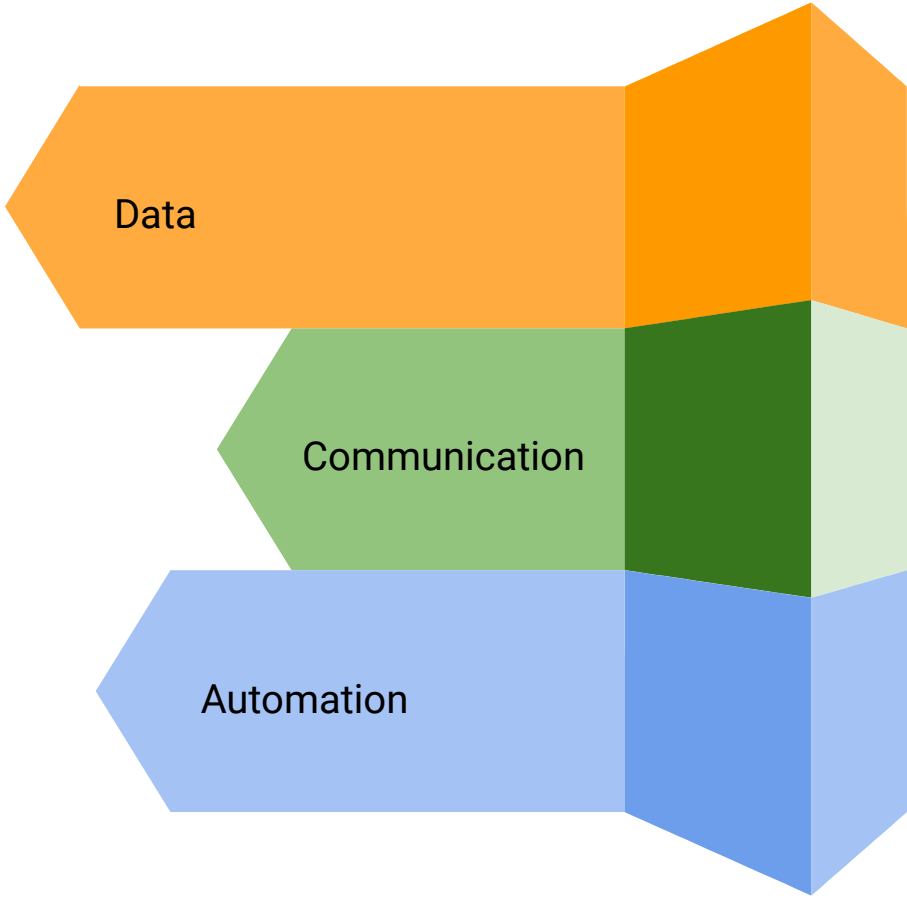
Aside from mentor reviews and mentor diversity, there is very little data being collected before, during, and after the three month accelerator session. Therefore, it is hard to find out what website features, program features, or events truly draw mentors to apply and become committed to the program.

Communication

Many mentors are not actively engaging in the techstars community (**Slack and Techstars Connect).**

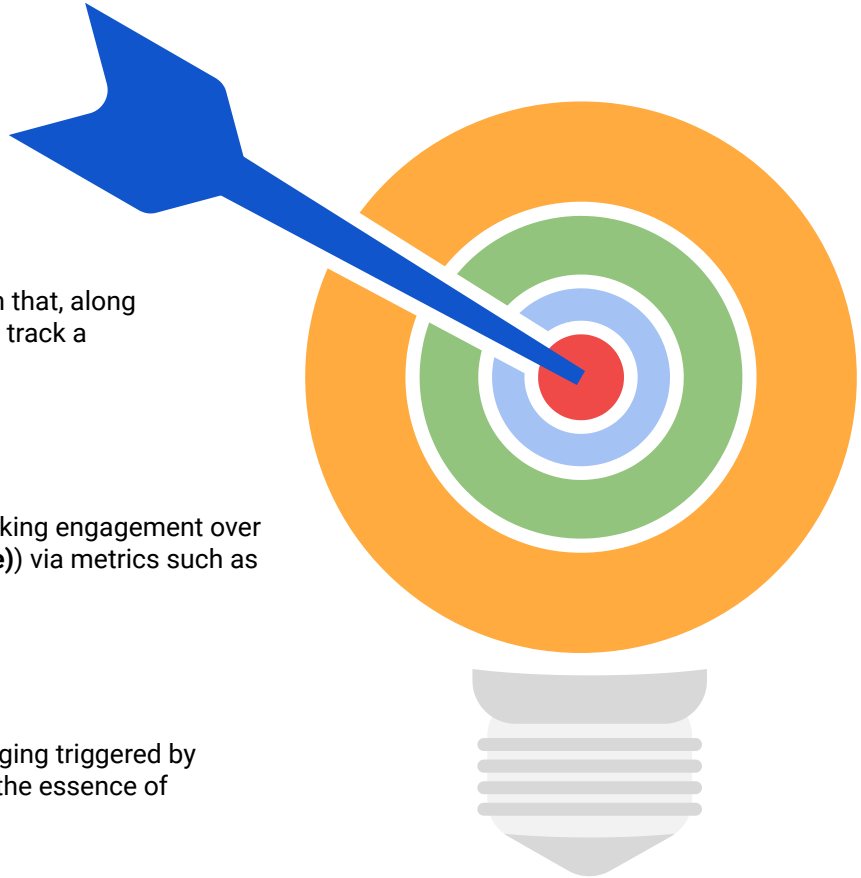
Automation

Personalized cross-channel communication is relatively difficult for a two person team. Reaching out electronically across multiple platforms (email, facebook, instagram, etc.) is an extremely time consuming endeavour.



Salesforce

Marketing Cloud and Journey Builder Solution



Journey Builder

Journey Builder is a drag-and-drop customizable platform that, along with marketing cloud will allow for data collection, as you track a mentor along his/her journey.

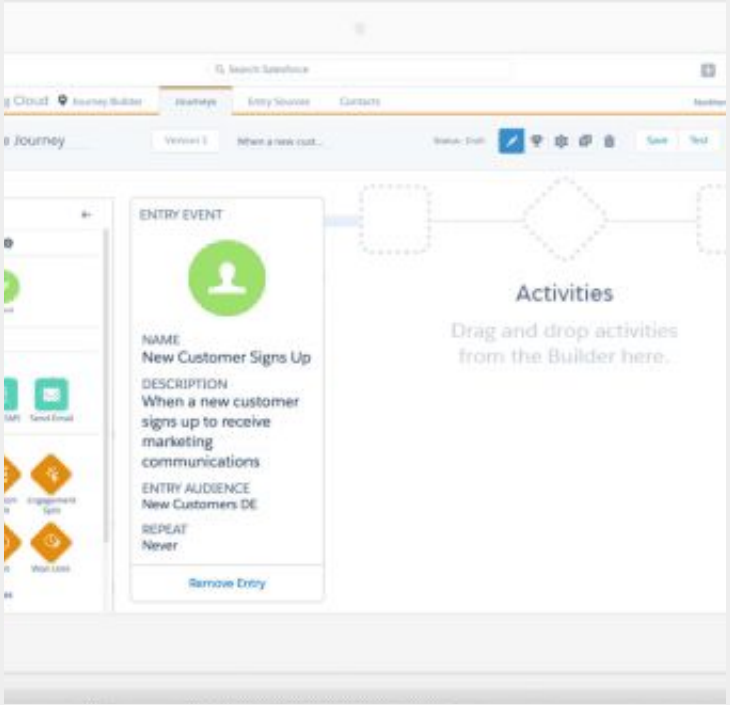
Marketing Analytics

Marketing analytics will use data-driven strategies to tracking engagement over time (throughout the mentor timeline**(insert slide #'s here)**) via metrics such as clicks, conversions, and web behavior.

Automation

Automated segmentation and email/social media messaging triggered by APIs and user interactions will save time, while retaining the essence of human communication and interaction.

Features of Journey Builder



Relative Simplicity

Journey Builder consists of simple drag and drop blocks that represent different events and triggers.

Goal Setting

For each type of customer journey, you can set a goal for engagement which determines the future of the customer journey.

Automation

Automated segmentation and email/social media messaging triggered by APIs and user interactions will save time, while retaining the essence of human communication and interaction.

“When identifying the experiences across all touchpoints from the customer’s perspective, it’s important not only to replicate great interactions but also to understand obstacles customers encounter that result in poor interactions. A seemingly small obstacle such as not easily finding the “Checkout” link on a website could result in significant revenue losses.”

Email, Mobile, and Web Marketing Pricing

Professional	Corporate	Basic
$1250	$3750	$400
Email Marketing	Email Marketing	Email Marketing
Content Creation	Content Creation	Content Creation
Integration with Sales Cloud	Integration with Sales Cloud	Integration with Sales Cloud
15K Automations	100K Automations	0 Automations
Data Extension (15GB)	Data Extension (45GB)	Data Extension (1GB)
Journey Builder w/additional fees	Journey Builder	No Journey Builder

Gaps with these solutions

Simplicity

Salesforce's interface is more complex than that of Marketo and will take at least one month to set up and get insightful analytics.

Cost/Budget

With Journey Builder, Techstars could be expected to pay ~$1500 for Marketing Cloud Pro. However, identifying the parts of the mentor journey that act of a a **bottleneck** will be crucial to increasing inbound of mentors.

GLOBAL AND LOCAL OUTCOME

Resolving Inefficiencies and Increasing Diversity Via a Three-Part Solution

Website Update + Community Gathering for Minorities

Updating the website will increase an inbound of mentors while simultaneously increasing diversity. Along with website updates, hosting community gatherings for minorities, and reaching out to more diverse entrepreneurial groups will increase mentor diversity by **~20-30%**

Using AI for the Vetting/Pairing Process

Implementing an AI program would save **75+ hours** in the mentor application vetting process via customizable taxonomies and machine learning.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud

Using Marketing Cloud and Journey builder will allow for a delicate balance between automation and the essential element of human interaction.

Thank you for this amazing opportunity!

TechStars,

Thank you for this amazing opportunity to work with you and learn about the mentor-founder experience. In creating this proposal, we have expanded our network, skills, and perspectives in a way that will prepare us for future work in developing our own startups, and we are truly grateful for the chance to participate in this challenge.

In this deck, we have chosen the best solutions and evidence from our three weeks of research. We worked to provide you with resources that you can easily implement into your January 2020 Cohort, and if you have any questions, please don't hesitate to reach out to us by email to discuss the proposal further.

Sincerely, Mukundh Murthy, Mikey Taylor, and Faith Inello

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